

Disambiguating “Governance Authority” Across the Trilogy

Author: Wenxin Li (Independent Researcher)

ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235

Date: May 15, 2026

License: Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

Attribution

This work derives from and formalizes commitments across the CKS theory trilogy: “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026), “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026), and “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026). It does not introduce new axioms. Its sole contribution is to trace the term *governance authority* as it appears across all three papers, to show that the term carries a consistent underlying meaning throughout, and to make explicit the three structural configurations — singular, tiered, and joint — that the concept takes on as the architecture’s coordination scope expands.

Abstract

The term “governance authority” appears in all three papers of the CKS theory trilogy and carries consistent meaning across them: human practitioners holding the three rights (inspect, modify, override) over substrate content and orchestration rules. The structural context in which that authority is configured, however, changes across papers. Paper 1 establishes a single governance authority over a single cell’s substrate. Paper 2 extends it to a three-tier hierarchy of governance authorities within a single organizational entity — cell-level, aspect-level, and Self-level practitioners, each holding the three rights at their respective scope. Paper 3 introduces two coexisting types: the home governance authority each participating Self retains over its own home substrate (unchanged from Papers 1 and 2), and the joint governance authority that participating Selves’ practitioners hold collectively over a shared substrate. The critical disambiguation at Paper 3 scope is that joint governance authority is additive, not substitutive: Paper 3 adds a new authority type for a new substrate object; it does not reduce, replace, or diminish home governance authority. Imprecision at Paper 3 scope — using “governance authority” without qualification — conflates two coexisting types that govern different substrate objects under different authorization mechanics.

1. The disambiguation need

“Governance authority” is the trilogy’s term for structural human authority over substrate content and orchestration rules. It is not a synonym for human involvement, human oversight, or human review. Governance authority in the CKS architecture is the availability of the three rights — to inspect any substrate content or orchestration rule, to modify any substrate content or orchestration rule, and to override any operation or LLM-produced output touching substrate content — as an architectural property, not as a procedural or workflow commitment.

The term is consistent across all three papers. What changes is not its definition but its structural configuration: who holds authority, over which substrate object, and how multiple authorities relate to one another when more than one organizational entity is present. Because the trilogy spans three progressively larger coordination scopes — cell scope (Paper 1), Self scope (Paper 2), inter-Self scope (Paper 3) — governance authority appears in three structurally different configurations across the trilogy.

The disambiguation risk is specific to Paper 3. Papers 1 and 2 are unambiguous: Paper 1 has one governance authority, and Paper 2 has a single organizational entity’s authority distributed across three tiers. Paper 3 introduces two types of governance authority that coexist within a single Full Aspect Integration (FAI) event. A reader who encounters “governance authority” in a Paper 3 passage without recognizing which type is meant may misread a passage about shared-substrate governance as applying to home-substrate governance, or vice versa. The secondary risk is inter-paper misreading: treating Paper 3’s joint governance authority as a novel invention unrelated to Paper 1’s single-scope authority model, when it is in fact a direct extension of the same concept to the multi-organizational setting.

2. Paper-by-paper usage

Paper 1 — Singular governance authority. Paper 1 establishes governance authority as the human practitioners who hold the three rights over a cell’s substrate and orchestration rules. The authority structure at Paper 1 scope is singular in two senses: there is one governance authority per cell’s substrate, and the authority’s structural relationship to the substrate is direct and flat — no tiers, no hierarchy within the authority itself, no partitioning of the three rights across different levels. One governance authority, one substrate, three rights.

The authority is structural, not operational. It does not require that the practitioners who hold it exercise it continuously or be present at every cell execution. The authority is available as an architectural property at all times: practitioners may inspect, modify, or override at any time they choose. Paper 1 also establishes that governance authority is authority over substrate content, not a labor commitment about who performs the work of producing that content. This authority-not-labor distinction carries forward intact through all three papers.

Paper 2 — Tiered governance authority within a single organizational entity. Paper 2 extends the coordination architecture to the Self — an integrated whole composed of aspects, each composed of cells. The introduction of three structural levels (cell, aspect, Self) requires a corresponding extension of governance authority: the three rights must be available at every level where substrate content exists, because all levels carry substrate content under the same human-governed commitment Paper 1 establishes.

Paper 2's governance authority structure is therefore tiered: cell governance practitioners hold the three rights over cell-scope substrate content and orchestration rules; aspect governance practitioners hold the three rights over the aspect's coordination specifications and the rules governing how its cells are organized; Self governance practitioners hold the three rights over the Self's integrating substrate content. Higher tiers may hold authority over lower-tier governance specifications — the rules that govern cells can themselves be governed by aspect-level authority, which can itself be governed by Self-level authority. The resulting structure is a hierarchically organized authority within one organizational entity, not multiple independent authorities. Paper 2's governance authority is intra-entity tiered, not inter-entity joint.

Paper 3 — Two coexisting types: home and joint. Paper 3 extends coordination to the inter-Self scope through the shared substrate — a CKS substrate temporarily constructed to mediate coordination between two or more Selves. The introduction of a substrate object that spans multiple Selves' home governance perimeters requires governance authority to be specified for an object that no single Self's home governance practitioners govern alone.

Paper 3 therefore introduces two types of governance authority that coexist within any FAI event. *Home governance authority* is each participating Self's governance practitioners governing that Self's home substrate. Home governance authority retains all properties established in Papers 1 and 2: the three rights over home substrate content and orchestration rules, available at all times, structural rather than operational, authority-not-labor. Home governance authority is not affected by participation in a FAI event. The participating Self's governance practitioners continue to hold the three rights over their home substrate during FAI participation exactly as they did before, at exactly the same scope. Paper 3 does not alter, diminish, or condition home governance authority.

Joint governance authority is the combined authority of all participating Selves' governance practitioners over the shared substrate. The shared substrate — as a CKS substrate — must itself be human-governed: inspectable, modifiable, and overridable by human practitioners. Because the shared substrate spans multiple Selves' home perimeters and is not owned by any one Self alone, the authority over it is held jointly by the governance practitioners of all participating Selves. The configuration substrate specifies how joint authority is exercised — including what approval mechanics apply for modify and override actions. The recursion closes at human-authored governance authority per Paper 1: the configuration substrate is itself substrate content under all six

Paper 1 commitments, with its content authored under joint authority.

3. The disambiguation

The three structural configurations of governance authority across the trilogy are related but architecturally distinct. Treating them as interchangeable produces misreadings in both directions: flattening them together loses the structural content that distinguishes each, and treating each as a novel invention disconnected from the others obscures the common concept they all instantiate.

Singular (Paper 1) vs. tiered (Paper 2). The move from Paper 1's singular authority to Paper 2's tiered authority is a move from one level to three levels within the same organizational entity. The three rights are preserved at every level; the change is that there are now three scopes of substrate content, each with its own governance practitioners, and the tiers are arranged so that higher-tier authority can govern lower-tier governance specifications. This is a structural elaboration of the same authority concept, not a replacement of it.

Tiered (Paper 2) vs. joint (Paper 3). The move from Paper 2's tiered authority to Paper 3's joint authority is a move from one organizational entity with multiple internal tiers to multiple organizational entities each with their own internal tier structure, all sharing authority over a new common substrate object. Joint authority is not an extension of Paper 2's tiers; it is a different structural arrangement. Paper 2's tiers are within one entity; Paper 3's joint authority is across entities. The distinction matters because the authorization mechanics differ: within-entity tier relationships are governed by the entity's own governance structure, while cross-entity joint authority requires agreed governance configurations in the configuration substrate.

The additive relationship at Paper 3 scope. The most critical disambiguation for Paper 3 is that home and joint governance authorities coexist as separate authority relationships over separate substrate objects. Home governance authority governs home substrate; joint governance authority governs shared substrate. These are different objects. A participating Self's home substrate is not governed by joint authority; the shared substrate is not governed by any single Self's home authority alone. The two types do not conflict because they govern different substrate objects with different perimeters.

This additive structure — joint governance authority added alongside preserved home governance authority — is what makes the phrase “undiminished home governance authority” architecturally precise. Home governance authority is not diminished because its scope (home substrate) is unchanged. It is not replaced because joint governance authority governs a different object (shared substrate). It is not subordinated because neither type of authority is above the other in a hierarchy; they are parallel types over non-overlapping substrate objects.

When reading a Paper 3 passage that refers to “governance authority,” the type must be specified for the reading to be precise: home governance authority when the passage concerns a Self’s home substrate or home perimeter; joint governance authority when the passage concerns the shared substrate or inter-Self perimeter. Unqualified usage creates the ambiguity this note closes.

4. Prior-art disambiguation claim

“Governance authority” throughout the CKS theory trilogy refers to human practitioners holding the three rights (inspect, modify, override) over substrate content and orchestration rules. The concept is consistent across all three papers. The structural configurations — singular in Paper 1, tiered within one entity in Paper 2, and home-plus-joint across multiple entities in Paper 3 — are three renderings of the same architectural commitment at progressively larger coordination scopes.

Paper 3’s joint governance authority is not a novel concept relative to Paper 1’s single-scope authority: it is the Paper 1 authority concept applied to a substrate object that spans multiple organizational entities, with the authorization mechanics for that multi-entity application specified in the configuration substrate under joint human authority. Anyone implementing joint governance authority over a shared substrate for inter-Self coordination is implementing the Paper 1 governance authority concept at inter-organizational scope.

Paper 3’s home governance authority is identical to the governance authority concept established in Papers 1 and 2. Participation in a FAI event does not alter, reduce, or condition it.

The three configurations — singular, tiered, joint — together constitute the prior art for any architecture that distributes human governance authority over AI coordination substrate at single-cell, multi-level intra-entity, or multi-entity inter-organizational scope. Each configuration is a derivation of the same concept, not a separate invention.

5. Precision guide for downstream use

When citing governance authority from any paper in the trilogy, the following precision discipline applies.

At Paper 1 scope: “governance authority” refers unambiguously to the single authority holding the three rights over a cell’s substrate. No qualification needed.

At Paper 2 scope: “governance authority” refers to the authority at the specified tier (cell, aspect, or Self). When the tier matters for the claim being made, specify it. When the claim applies at all tiers uniformly — as the three-rights commitment does — unqualified use is acceptable.

At Paper 3 scope: “governance authority” requires qualification. “Home governance authority” names the authority of a participating Self’s practitioners over that Self’s home substrate. “Joint

governance authority” names the combined authority of all participating Selves’ practitioners over the shared substrate. Unqualified use at Paper 3 scope creates genuine ambiguity that downstream claims may not tolerate.

The qualification requirement at Paper 3 scope is not a sign that governance authority is more complex or weaker at Paper 3 scope. It is the sign that Paper 3 introduces a richer authority architecture — two types coexisting over two substrate objects — than either prior paper requires. Qualification is the precision instrument that makes that richer architecture readable without confusion.

6. Conclusion

“Governance authority” is one concept instantiated in three structural configurations across the CKS theory trilogy. The concept is stable: human practitioners holding the three rights over substrate content and orchestration rules, as an architectural property, not a workflow or labor commitment. The configurations are structurally distinct: singular at Paper 1’s cell scope, tiered within a single entity at Paper 2’s Self scope, and home-plus-joint at Paper 3’s inter-Self scope. The central disambiguation — that Paper 3’s joint governance authority is additive, not substitutive — is what makes the trilogy’s governance architecture coherent: every substrate object in every paper, at every scope, is human-governed by practitioners holding the three rights. No scope expansion in the trilogy weakens that commitment.